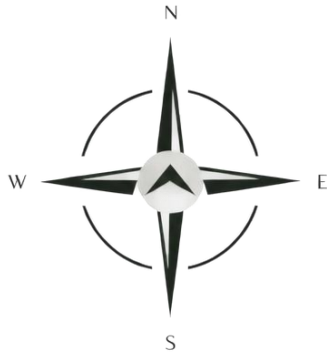




OUTBOUND

TRAVEL PLANNING • EST. 2026

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THE THAILAND GUIDE

A practical guide to planning a better trip

2026 EDITION

OUTBOUND.

Travel planning, rethought.

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01 — THAILAND, DONE PROPERLY

Thailand is one of the easiest countries in Southeast Asia to travel around, but that does not mean it is easy to plan well. Bangkok, Chiang Mai, the northern mountains, Phuket, Krabi, Koh Samui, Koh Phangan, Koh Tao and the smaller islands can all look like obvious additions when you start building a route. The problem is that trying to see everything can turn a great holiday into a sequence of flights, ferries, hotel check-ins and rushed sightseeing.

The better approach is to decide **what you actually want Thailand to be**. For some travellers, that means Bangkok, temples, food and northern Thailand. For others, it means island-hopping, diving and beaches. For others, it is nightlife, Muay Thai, markets and street food. Thailand works particularly well when you combine a few of these experiences rather than trying to collect every famous destination.

The classic first-time Thailand trip usually has three ingredients: **Bangkok, northern Thailand and the islands**. Bangkok gives you the energy and culture of the capital. Chiang Mai provides a completely different pace, with Lanna culture, temples, mountains and food. The islands then provide the obvious change of rhythm: beaches, swimming, diving, boat trips and evenings that can be as busy or as quiet as you want them to be.

The biggest decision is therefore not *where should I go?* It is **which side of Thailand deserves the most time?**

If you have one week, don't attempt Bangkok, Chiang Mai and multiple islands. Choose two major experiences. If you have ten days, three bases can work well. Two weeks gives you enough time for a classic Thailand route

without feeling constantly rushed. Three weeks gives you the option of adding a more adventurous northern section, another island or simply more time in places you already like.

Thailand is also unusually good at supporting different travel styles. You can travel cheaply using guesthouses, trains, local restaurants and ferries, or build a much more comfortable trip around boutique hotels, private transfers, premium island resorts and organised experiences. The underlying route can be similar even when the budgets are completely different.

That flexibility is one of Thailand's biggest strengths. **You don't need to travel in one particular way to enjoy it.**

The key is choosing destinations that actually complement each other.

Bangkok gives you intensity. Chiang Mai gives you culture and mountains. The Andaman coast gives you dramatic limestone scenery and islands. The Gulf gives you a different island-hopping environment, with Koh Samui, Koh Phangan and Koh Tao each offering something different.

This means you can build a trip around contrast rather than distance.

A strong itinerary might be **Bangkok → Chiang Mai → islands**.

Another could be **Bangkok → Krabi → Koh Lanta**.

A diving-focused trip could be **Bangkok → Koh Tao → Koh Phangan**.

A slower trip could simply be **Bangkok → Chiang Mai → one island**.

There is no prize for visiting the most destinations.

OUTBOUND RULE: Thailand should feel like a holiday, not a transport challenge.

If adding another destination means losing half a day to a transfer, changing hotels again and squeezing another activity into an already busy schedule, ask whether the destination genuinely improves the trip.

Thailand has enough to keep you coming back.

You don't need to see all of Thailand in one trip. You need to choose the Thailand that suits you.

02 — BEFORE YOU GO

Thailand is relatively straightforward to travel through, but a few decisions made before you leave can have a huge impact on the trip.

The first is **when you're going**.

Thailand does not have one single weather pattern. Conditions vary between regions, particularly between the Andaman coast and the Gulf islands. That means the “best time to visit Thailand” depends partly on the route you are building.

The cooler and generally drier period is typically the most popular time for many travellers, particularly from around November through February. March to May can become extremely hot, while the southwest monsoon influences much of the country through the wetter months.

But don't automatically rule out the wet season.

Rain does not necessarily mean constant rain all day. You can still have excellent trips outside peak season, often with fewer crowds and lower prices. The important thing is to understand the conditions for **your specific destinations**.

If beaches are the main reason you're travelling, look at the specific coast you plan to visit before booking.

If northern Thailand is a major part of the trip, also consider air quality. The annual burning season can cause periods of poor air quality in northern areas, particularly around Chiang Mai. Check current conditions if you're travelling during the relevant period rather than relying on a generic "best time" guide.

VISA & ENTRY

Entry requirements can change, so always check the current rules for your passport shortly before travelling.

For British and Irish passport holders, Thailand's current visa-exemption rules are particularly important to check because the policy has recently been revised. The Royal Thai Embassy in London currently states that, from **15 September 2026**, eligible British and Irish passport holders can enter Thailand visa-free for tourism for up to 30 days under the revised exemption scheme.

The **Thailand Digital Arrival Card (TDAC)** is also required for foreign travellers and must be completed within three days before arrival. The TDAC is free and is separate from a visa.

Because entry policies can change, this guide should be treated as a planning resource rather than a substitute for checking the official requirements immediately before departure.

MONEY

Thailand is still one of the easier countries in Southeast Asia for travellers to manage on a range of budgets.

The local currency is the **Thai baht (THB)**.

Cards are widely accepted in hotels, shopping centres, chain restaurants and many tourist businesses, but cash remains extremely useful for street food, markets, taxis, smaller restaurants and local businesses.

Don't arrive assuming you can use a card for absolutely everything.

A sensible approach is to carry some cash while keeping the majority of your spending accessible through your normal banking methods.

TRANSPORT

Thailand's transport network is one of the reasons the country works so well for first-time Southeast Asia travellers.

Domestic flights make long distances relatively easy.

Trains are particularly useful for certain journeys and can be part of the experience rather than simply a way of getting from A to B.

Buses and minivans connect many tourist destinations.

Ferries become important when you move onto the islands.

The mistake is assuming that a two-hour flight means a two-hour travel day. Add airport transfers, check-in, waiting and the journey from the destination airport and you may have lost half a day.

The same applies to ferries.

A boat advertised as a two-hour journey may involve an hour getting to the pier, waiting to board, the boat itself and another transfer when you arrive.

TEMPLES & CULTURE

Thailand is predominantly Buddhist, and temples are an important part of everyday life.

Dress respectfully when visiting temples and follow local instructions. Some religious sites require shoulders and knees to be covered.

Shoes are often removed before entering certain buildings.

The easiest approach is simply to observe what locals are doing and follow the rules displayed at the site.

Remember that temples are places of worship rather than just tourist attractions.

SCOOTERS

Scooters are everywhere in Thailand, particularly on islands.

That doesn't mean every traveller should rent one.

Road conditions, traffic, unfamiliar vehicles and weather can make riding significantly more dangerous than it appears.

If you do ride, make sure you have the appropriate licence, insurance and experience.

If you don't, use taxis, songthaews, local transport or a driver.

Saving a few pounds on transport isn't worth compromising the entire holiday.

TRAVEL INSURANCE

Travel insurance should match the trip you're actually taking.

If you're planning diving, motorbike riding, trekking, climbing, kayaking or other activities, check that your policy covers them.

Thailand is easy to travel around, but that doesn't mean every activity is automatically covered by a standard policy.

WHAT TO PACK

Thailand rewards travelling light.

You will probably move between cities, trains, airports, ferries and hotels, so a huge suitcase quickly becomes annoying.

Bring lightweight clothes, comfortable shoes, swimwear, sun protection and something that can cover your shoulders and knees for temples.

If you're travelling north or into the mountains, bring a light layer.

If you're planning to dive, trek or spend significant time outdoors, pack around those activities rather than assuming everything can be bought when you arrive.

THE BIGGEST PRE-TRIP MISTAKE

The biggest planning mistake is booking everything before deciding on the route.

Book the international flights first.

Then decide the major regions.

Then check the important domestic connections.

Then build your accommodation around the route.

Don't end up with non-refundable hotels in five destinations before you've worked out how you're getting between them.

OUTBOUND TIP: Thailand is easy enough that you don't need to plan every hour before you arrive. Plan the structure, lock in the important connections and leave room for the trip to breathe.

03 — BUILD YOUR ROUTE

Thailand is one of the easiest countries to over-plan.

Open a map and it is tempting to draw a line through Bangkok, Ayutthaya, Chiang Mai, Pai, Phuket, Krabi, Koh Lanta, Koh Phi Phi, Koh Samui, Koh Phangan and Koh Tao.

Technically, you can. You probably shouldn't.

The first step is deciding which **regional combination** suits your trip.

THE THREE CORE AREAS

Think of Thailand in three broad sections.

Bangkok & Central Thailand gives you the capital, temples, markets, food and access to places such as Ayutthaya.

Northern Thailand gives you Chiang Mai, mountains, temples, markets and a slower cultural experience.

Southern Thailand is where the trip becomes about beaches and islands.

Once you understand those three sections, route planning becomes much easier.

For a first trip, the most useful question is:

Do I want north + islands, or islands + more islands?

HOW MANY PLACES?

Trip length	Recommended major bases	OUTBOUND approach
5–7 days	2	Keep it simple
8–10 days	3	Classic first trip
11–14 days	3–4	Add a region or slow down
15–21 days	4–5	More depth and flexibility
3+ weeks	5+	Explore selectively

These aren't rules. They're a defence against overplanning.

Three nights is a useful benchmark for most major destinations. If somewhere takes half a day to reach, give yourself enough time for the destination to justify that journey.

CHOOSE YOUR ISLAND REGION

This is one of the most important Thailand decisions.

The **Andaman side** includes Phuket, Krabi, Koh Phi Phi, Koh Lanta and other islands.

The **Gulf side** includes Koh Samui, Koh Phangan and Koh Tao.

Don't automatically try to do both.

They offer different experiences, but you can get plenty from one side.

If you have seven days and want beaches, choosing one island region is usually better than spending half the trip crossing the country.

ANDAMAN

The Andaman coast is a strong choice for dramatic scenery, limestone cliffs, island trips and beaches.

Krabi works particularly well as a base for exploring the surrounding area.

Phuket offers the broadest range of accommodation, nightlife and infrastructure, but different parts of the island feel very different.

Koh Lanta is slower and more relaxed.

Koh Phi Phi is famous for dramatic scenery and a lively atmosphere, but don't choose it expecting complete tranquillity.

GULF

The Gulf islands create a different style of island trip.

Koh Samui is the easiest all-rounder, with a wide range of accommodation, restaurants and beaches.

Koh Phangan is famous for the Full Moon Party, but the island is much more than one night of nightlife.

Koh Tao is particularly strong for diving and has a younger, backpacker-friendly atmosphere.

You can combine all three, but again, you don't have to.

THINK IN CONTRASTS

A good route changes the experience every few days.

Bangkok → Chiang Mai → Koh Tao gives you:

city → mountains → island.

Bangkok → Krabi → Koh Lanta gives you:

city → dramatic coast → slow island.

Bangkok → Koh Phangan → Koh Tao gives you:

city → social island → diving island.

This is more useful than simply counting destinations.

THE TRANSFER TEST

Before adding another destination, ask:

How long will it actually take to get there?

Not the advertised flight or ferry time. The whole journey.

Hotel → airport → check-in → flight → baggage → transfer → hotel.

If the answer is six hours and you're only staying two nights, question the decision.

THE THREE-NIGHT RULE

Three nights is a strong default for Thailand. Two nights can work for a compact destination.

Four or five nights is worthwhile when you want to slow down or the destination has enough experiences to support it. One night is usually a warning sign.

There are exceptions, but if your itinerary contains several one-night stays, you've probably tried to fit too much in.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't build Thailand by asking, "What else can I fit in?"

Build it by asking:

"What would make this trip better?"

04 — BANGKOK

Bangkok is not simply the place you fly into before heading to the islands.

It deserves to be experienced. The city combines enormous temples, street food, rooftop bars, shopping centres, markets, modern skyscrapers and some of the most intense street life in Southeast Asia.

The trick is not trying to see all of Bangkok. It is understanding **which side of the city you want to experience**.

HOW LONG?

For most first-time visitors, **three nights is a strong starting point**. Two nights can work if Bangkok is part of a short trip.

Four or five nights makes sense if you enjoy cities, food, nightlife and exploring neighbourhoods. Don't spend six days in Bangkok simply because you don't know where else to go. But don't give the city one rushed night either.

THE OLD CITY

The historic centre is where you'll find many of Bangkok's most important temples and landmarks.

Wat Pho, Wat Arun and the Grand Palace/Wat Phra Kaew area form the backbone of a classic first visit.

These are worth seeing, but don't try to visit every temple in Bangkok. Choose a few and actually spend time looking around. The Grand Palace area can become very busy, so arriving earlier can make the experience considerably more enjoyable.

Bangkok's temples are not simply decorative buildings. They are active religious sites, so dress appropriately and behave respectfully.

THE CHAO PHRAYA

The Chao Phraya River gives you a completely different perspective of the city. River boats can also be useful transport rather than simply a sightseeing activity.

Combine a river journey with the Old City and you can experience several major sights without spending the entire day in road traffic.

CHINATOWN

Yaowarat is one of the best areas to experience Bangkok's food culture.

Go hungry. The streets come alive in the evening with restaurants, stalls, seafood, desserts and crowds. You don't need a complicated plan. Walk, look at what's busy, try things and keep moving.

MARKETS

Bangkok has markets for almost every type of traveller. Chatuchak is one of the most famous and works particularly well if you happen to be in the city at the weekend. But don't assume every famous market needs to be on your itinerary.

If you're already spending hours exploring Chinatown, local neighbourhoods and food streets, another market may add less than you expect.

ROOFTOPS & NIGHTLIFE

Bangkok's skyline is one of the best places to understand how modern the city has become. Rooftop bars can be expensive by Thai standards, but the experience can justify the cost. For nightlife, choose the area and atmosphere that matches you.

Don't automatically head to the most famous street because it appears in every guide. Bangkok's nightlife is much broader than one tourist strip.

FOOD

Food should be treated as one of Bangkok's main attractions. Street food is often where the city feels most alive. Try local dishes rather than eating the same familiar meals you could order at home.

Pad Thai, boat noodles, mango sticky rice, som tam, grilled meats, curries and regional dishes all deserve attention, but don't turn eating into a checklist.

Follow busy stalls and places with a strong local crowd.

WHERE TO STAY

For a first trip, convenience matters more than finding the cheapest room. Areas around **Sukhumvit, Silom, riverside Bangkok and the Old City** can all work, but they provide different experiences.

If nightlife and restaurants matter, Sukhumvit may be convenient. If temples and historic Bangkok matter more, staying closer to the Old City can reduce travel time. If you want a more atmospheric stay, the riverside can be appealing.

HOW TO SPEND THREE DAYS

A strong three-night Bangkok structure might look like this:

Day 1: Arrive, settle in, explore your neighbourhood and have an easy first evening.

Day 2: Old City, temples, river and Chinatown.

Day 3: Markets, shopping, food and nightlife.

Day 4: Depart for your next destination.

This leaves enough structure to make the most of the city without turning every hour into an appointment.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Bangkok is worth experiencing properly, but you don't need to fall in love with the city to have a great Thailand trip.

If three nights is enough for you, move on.

If you love cities and food, stay longer.

Don't judge Bangkok from the airport transfer.

05 — CHIANG MAI

Chiang Mai is where Thailand's pace changes.

After Bangkok's traffic, crowds and skyscrapers, the north feels slower, greener and more relaxed.

The city combines **Lanna culture, temples, markets, food and mountain landscapes**, making it one of the strongest additions to a first Thailand itinerary.

HOW LONG?

Give Chiang Mai **three to four nights** for a first visit.

Two nights can work if you're short on time, but three or four allows you to experience the city without rushing. If you're using Chiang Mai as a base for mountain trips, trekking or surrounding villages, consider staying longer.

THE OLD CITY

The Old City is the natural starting point. Its temples, lanes, cafés and restaurants make it easy to explore on foot or by short local journeys. Don't turn the day into a temple marathon. Choose a handful that interest you and spend time wandering between them.

DOI SUTHEP

Wat Phra That Doi Suthep is one of Chiang Mai's defining landmarks.

Its position above the city makes it worthwhile for both the temple and the views. Visit early or later in the day if you want to avoid the strongest heat.

DOI INTHANON

If you want mountains and nature, **Doi Inthanon** provides a very different experience from central Chiang Mai. Thailand's highest mountain is surrounded by forests, waterfalls and hiking opportunities. It works particularly well as a day trip if nature is a priority.

MARKETS & FOOD

Chiang Mai is one of Thailand's best cities for food.

Northern Thai cuisine is noticeably different from the food you'll encounter elsewhere. Try **khao soi**, one of the region's defining dishes. Night markets also provide an easy way to sample food, shop and experience the city after dark.

NIMMAN

Nimman provides the more modern side of Chiang Mai. Cafés, restaurants, bars, shops and a younger atmosphere make it a good contrast with the Old City. You don't have to choose one or the other.

Use the Old City for history and temples and Nimman for food, cafés and evenings.

ELEPHANT EXPERIENCES

Be careful with elephant tourism. The fact that an experience is marketed as ethical does not automatically make it so. Avoid experiences based around riding, performances or forced interaction.

If elephants are important to you, research the organisation properly and prioritise welfare over getting the perfect photograph.

THE NORTH BEYOND CHIANG MAI

Chiang Mai can also be a gateway to other northern experiences.

Pai is the obvious addition for travellers looking for a smaller mountain town, backpacker atmosphere and scenic surroundings.

But Pai is not automatically necessary. The journey takes time, and the experience is quite different from Chiang Mai. Go because you want Pai. Don't go because every backpacker itinerary includes it.

AIR QUALITY

Northern Thailand can experience periods of poor air quality during the burning season.

If you're travelling during the relevant months, check current air-quality conditions before committing to a long northern itinerary. This is particularly important if outdoor activities are a major reason for visiting.

THE PERFECT CHIANG MAI RHYTHM

A good Chiang Mai trip alternates between activity and downtime. Spend one morning exploring temples. Have a long lunch. Walk through the Old City. Spend an evening at a market. Then take a day trip into the mountains. You don't need to be moving constantly.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Chiang Mai is one of the best places in Thailand to slow down.

If your Thailand trip is only seven days, it may be a choice between Chiang Mai and a longer island section. If you have ten days or more, adding Chiang Mai becomes much easier to justify. **City → north → islands** is one of Thailand's strongest rhythms.

06 — THE ISLANDS

Thailand's islands are where itinerary planning gets dangerous. Not because they're difficult to visit. Because **there are too many good options**. The answer is not to visit them all.

The answer is to choose the island experience that matches the holiday you want.

THE ANDAMAN SIDE

The Andaman coast is home to some of Thailand's most recognisable landscapes.

Limestone cliffs, turquoise water, beaches and boat trips make the region particularly attractive for first-time visitors.

PHUKET

Phuket is Thailand's most developed island destination. That is both its strength and its weakness. You have huge accommodation choice, restaurants, nightlife, beaches, airports and easy access to other destinations. But some parts can feel heavily developed.

Choose your area carefully.

Patong is the obvious choice if nightlife is the priority.

Other areas can be much better suited to travellers who want beaches and relaxation without being surrounded by nightlife. Don't write off Phuket because you've heard it is "too touristy". Instead, decide whether you actually want the convenience and infrastructure it provides.

KRABI

Krabi is one of the strongest choices for first-time island travellers who want scenery as much as beaches. **Ao Nang** is the practical base, while **Railay** provides the dramatic limestone landscape that the region is famous for. Krabi also works well for boat trips and access to nearby islands.

For many travellers, **Bangkok → Krabi → island** is a more natural route than trying to combine Phuket, Krabi and several islands.

KOH PHI PHI

Phi Phi is spectacular. It is also busy. The island is particularly suited to travellers who want dramatic scenery, boat trips, social atmosphere and nightlife. If you want complete peace and quiet, it may not be your ideal base.

Visit for what it actually offers rather than the version you imagine from photographs.

KOH LANTA

Koh Lanta is the slower option. It is a strong choice if you want beaches, restaurants and island life without making nightlife the centre of the trip. It can work particularly well for couples, longer stays and travellers who want to settle somewhere.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: If you want a relaxed island finish, Koh Lanta is often a better choice than trying to squeeze three famous islands into five days.

THE GULF ISLANDS

The Gulf side offers a different island combination.

KOH SAMUI

Koh Samui is the easiest all-rounder. It has a major airport, extensive accommodation, beaches, restaurants, nightlife and access to surrounding islands. It works particularly well for travellers who want convenience.

You can build a complete island holiday around Samui without needing to move elsewhere.

KOH PHANGAN

Koh Phangan is famous for the **Full Moon Party**, but reducing the entire island to that event misses the point. Away from the main nightlife areas, you can find beaches, viewpoints, wellness experiences and quieter accommodation. If nightlife is your priority, time your trip around the events you actually want to attend.

If it isn't, avoid building your entire itinerary around them.

KOH TAO

Koh Tao is particularly well known for diving. It is also popular with younger travellers and backpackers. If learning to dive is one of the main reasons you're visiting Thailand, Koh Tao becomes a much stronger candidate.

If diving isn't important to you, there may be better islands for your particular trip.

WHICH SIDE SHOULD YOU CHOOSE?

The most important rule is simple:

Don't try to do Andaman and Gulf islands in the same short trip unless you have a very good reason.

The two regions are not next door to each other. Moving between them consumes time. For a seven-day trip, pick one. For ten days, you can still get a much better holiday by staying on one side. For two or three weeks, combining both becomes more realistic.

HOW MANY ISLANDS?

One island is enough. Two islands can be excellent. Three islands can work if they're naturally connected. Four islands in ten days is usually too much. If you're spending two nights on each island, you're probably spending more time moving than relaxing.

OUTBOUND RULE: Your island itinerary should have at least one place where you stop moving.

That is the entire point.

07 — GETTING AROUND THAILAND

Thailand's transport network is one of its biggest advantages.

You can combine **domestic flights, trains, buses, ferries, taxis and local transport** relatively easily. But the best transport option depends on how much time you have.

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS

Flying makes the most sense when crossing large distances. Bangkok to Chiang Mai is a classic example. Bangkok to Phuket, Krabi or Koh Samui can also make sense depending on your route. If you have ten days, don't automatically choose a 12-hour overnight journey because it is cheaper.

Compare the **total value of your time**.

TRAINS

Thailand's trains can be part of the travel experience. The overnight train to Chiang Mai is particularly popular because it allows you to travel while sleeping rather than losing a full daytime journey. If you enjoy slower travel, trains can be an excellent option. If your trip is extremely short, flying may be more sensible.

BUSES & MINIVANS

Buses and minivans connect destinations that aren't well served by rail. They can be inexpensive and convenient, but journey times depend heavily on traffic and road conditions. Don't build a tight itinerary around an estimated arrival time.

FERRIES

Once you're travelling around the islands, ferries become part of everyday travel. Check which pier your service actually leaves from and how you're getting there. A hotel that looks close to the ferry terminal on a map may still require a long transfer.

If you are connecting a ferry to a flight, **leave a substantial buffer**.

LOCAL TRANSPORT

Bangkok has an excellent combination of BTS and MRT systems, alongside taxis and river transport. Elsewhere, you'll encounter taxis, songthaews, tuk-tuks and app-based transport.

Agree on prices when appropriate and confirm the destination before setting off.

SCOOTERS

Again: only ride if you're properly licensed, insured and experienced. A scooter can be a fantastic way to explore an island. It can also turn a holiday into a medical emergency very quickly.

Don't let peer pressure determine your transport choice.

THE TRANSPORT DAY

The most important concept is understanding what a transfer actually costs. Suppose a ferry takes two hours.

You still need to:

Leave your hotel. Reach the pier. Check in. Wait. Take the ferry. Collect your bags. Find onward transport. Reach the next hotel. A “two-hour transfer” might therefore consume most of your day. Count the **whole journey**, not the headline travel time.

WHEN TO BOOK

Book your important long-distance transport before the trip if your itinerary depends on it. Flights are particularly important around busy periods. Popular overnight trains should also be booked ahead.

Island ferries can usually be arranged more flexibly, but don't assume every service operates at the frequency you expect.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Never schedule a critical international flight immediately after a long ferry or complex overland journey.

Give yourself a buffer. One delayed boat should not destroy your entire trip.

OUTBOUND TIP: The best transport option isn't always the cheapest. It is the option that gives you the best combination of **price, time, comfort and reliability**.

08 — FOOD & EXPERIENCES

Thailand is one of the easiest countries in the world to build a trip around food. But don't reduce Thai food to Pad Thai and green curry. The country has enormous regional variation.

BANGKOK FOOD

Bangkok is where you can eat extremely well without spending much money. Street food, markets, noodle shops, seafood restaurants and modern Thai restaurants all sit alongside each other. Try dishes you don't recognise. Follow busy places.

Don't assume the most expensive restaurant is automatically the best experience.

NORTHERN THAI FOOD

Northern Thailand has its own food identity.

Khao soi is the obvious dish to try in Chiang Mai, but there is much more to explore.

Ask locals or restaurant staff what they recommend rather than ordering the same dishes you've already eaten in Bangkok.

SOUTHERN FOOD

Southern Thai food is often bolder and spicier. Curries, seafood and regional dishes can be excellent. If you enjoy spicy food, this is where you can push yourself. If you don't, tell the restaurant.

STREET FOOD RULE

Don't judge a food stall by how polished it looks. A simple stall with a queue of local customers can be a better experience than a restaurant designed entirely for tourists.

Use common sense around food hygiene, particularly with seafood and anything that has clearly been sitting out for a long time.

COOKING CLASSES

A cooking class can be one of the better tourist activities in Thailand because you actually take something away from it.

Choose a class that includes a market visit if that appeals to you. You'll understand the ingredients much better once you've seen where they come from.

MUAY THAI

Watching Muay Thai can be a great cultural experience, particularly if you're interested in combat sports. If you want to train rather than simply watch, Thailand is also an obvious place to do it. You don't need to become a serious fighter.

Even a short introductory session can be memorable.

TEMPLES

Don't measure a Thailand trip by the number of temples you've visited. Visit the important ones.

Then give yourself time to experience the surrounding city.

BOAT TRIPS

Boat trips are one of the easiest ways to experience the southern coastline. Choose trips based on what you actually want. If you want snorkelling, prioritise the marine experience. If you want photography, prioritise scenery.

If you want a quiet beach day, don't book the largest party boat available.

DIVING

If diving is important, choose the island around the diving rather than adding diving as an afterthought. Koh Tao is particularly associated with dive courses and beginner-friendly diving, while other destinations offer different underwater environments.

Choose reputable operators and don't let price be the only consideration.

ELEPHANTS

Treat elephant tourism carefully. Avoid riding, performances and experiences that involve forced interaction.

If you want to see elephants, research the operator's welfare practices rather than relying on the word "ethical" in the marketing.

NIGHTLIFE

Thailand can offer almost any type of nightlife. Bangkok gives you rooftop bars, clubs and late-night food. Chiang Mai is more relaxed. Phuket and the southern islands can range from sophisticated beach bars to full-on party destinations. Koh Phangan has its famous Full Moon events.

The important thing is choosing the nightlife that fits your trip. You don't have to go to a Full Moon Party just because you're in Thailand.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't collect experiences because they're famous.

Collect the experiences you'll actually remember.

09 — THE ROUTES

Thailand is one of the countries where itinerary maths matters. These routes assume that **Day 1 is your arrival day and the final day is your departure day.**

So:

7 days = usually 6 nights.

10 days = usually 9 nights.

14 days = usually 13 nights.

That distinction matters when deciding how many destinations you can realistically fit in.

7 DAYS — KEEP IT SIMPLE

Seven days is enough for an excellent Thailand trip.

It is not enough to do everything.

OPTION A — BANGKOK + CHIANG MAI

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Arrive, explore the Old City, eat your way through the city and experience Bangkok's nightlife.

Days 4–6 — Chiang Mai

Fly north and spend three nights around the Old City and surrounding area.

Day 7 — Departure

This is the best option if culture, food and cities matter more to you than beaches.

OPTION B — BANGKOK + BEACH

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Three nights exploring the city.

Days 4–6 — Krabi or Phuket

Fly south and spend three nights on the coast.

Day 7 — Departure

This is the easiest option if your priority is **city + beach**.

OPTION C — BANGKOK + KOH SAMUI

Three nights in Bangkok followed by three nights on Koh Samui gives you a straightforward city-to-island combination.

This is particularly attractive if you want a simple trip with minimal moving around.

WHAT NOT TO DO

Bangkok → Chiang Mai → Phuket → Phi Phi → Krabi → Koh Samui in seven days.

You can technically make some of those connections. You cannot properly experience them all.

10 DAYS — THE OUTBOUND DEFAULT

Ten days is where Thailand becomes much more flexible.

OPTION A — BANGKOK + CHIANG MAI + ISLAND

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Three nights.

Days 4–6 — Chiang Mai

Three nights.

Days 7–9 — Island

Three nights around Krabi, Phuket, Koh Samui or another island destination.

Day 10 — Departure

This is probably the strongest all-round first Thailand route.

You get:

city → mountains → beach.

Every section feels different.

OPTION B — BANGKOK + KRABI + KOH LANTA

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Days 4–6 — Krabi

Use Krabi for beaches, limestone scenery and boat trips.

Days 7–9 — Koh Lanta

Slow down and finish the trip on a quieter island.

Day 10 — Departure

This route is particularly good for travellers who don't care about northern Thailand and want to prioritise beaches.

OPTION C — BANGKOK + KOH TAO + KOH PHANGAN

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Days 4–6 — Koh Tao

Diving, snorkelling and island life.

Days 7–9 — Koh Phangan

Choose between nightlife or a quieter side of the island.

Day 10 — Departure

This is the strongest route if your trip is primarily about **island life and diving**.

OPTION D — BANGKOK + CHIANG MAI + PHUKET

This gives you a little more comfort and infrastructure than a multi-island route.

Three nights Bangkok. Three nights Chiang Mai. Three nights Phuket. Day 10 departure. It's straightforward and easy to execute.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Ten days is enough for **three major bases**.

Don't turn it into five.

14 DAYS — THE CLASSIC THAILAND TRIP

Two weeks gives you enough time to build a genuinely varied Thailand itinerary.

OPTION A — BANGKOK + CHIANG MAI + KRABI + KOH LANTA

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Three nights exploring the capital.

Days 4–6 — Chiang Mai

Three nights in the north.

Days 7–10 — Krabi

Four nights on the Andaman coast.

Days 11–13 — Koh Lanta

Three nights slowing down on the island.

Day 14 — Departure

This is one of the strongest two-week routes for a first-time visitor.

You get:

city → culture → dramatic coast → relaxed island.

OPTION B — BANGKOK + CHIANG MAI + KOH SAMUI + KOH PHANGAN

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Days 4–6 — Chiang Mai

Days 7–10 — Koh Samui

Four nights.

Days 11–13 — Koh Phangan

Three nights.

Day 14 — Departure

Choose this route if the island section is a major part of the holiday.

OPTION C — BANGKOK + CHIANG MAI + SOUTHERN THAILAND

You don't actually need multiple islands. Spend three nights Bangkok. Four nights Chiang Mai. Six nights around one southern destination. This can be a better holiday than constantly moving.

OUTBOUND RULE: Two weeks does not mean you need twice as many destinations.

It means you can give the destinations you choose **more time**.

21 DAYS — THE FULL EXPERIENCE

Three weeks gives you enough time to build a broader Thailand trip.

A strong route could be:

Days 1–3 — Bangkok

Explore the capital.

Days 4–7 — Chiang Mai

Four nights in the north, with time for the city and a mountain day trip.

Days 8–11 — Krabi

Four nights exploring the Andaman coast.

Days 12–15 — Koh Lanta

Four nights slowing down.

Days 16–19 — Koh Tao

Four nights focused on diving, beaches and island life.

Days 20–21 — Bangkok / departure buffer

Return towards Bangkok and use the final period as a buffer before your international flight. This route is deliberately slower. You don't need to add Phuket, Phi Phi, Koh Samui and Koh Phangan simply because you have three weeks. If you want nightlife, swap part of the island section for Koh Phangan. If diving is the priority, spend longer around Koh Tao. If relaxation is the priority, extend Koh Lanta.

THE ALTERNATIVE 21-DAY ROUTE

For travellers who want more northern Thailand, you could instead build:

Bangkok → Chiang Mai → Pai → Krabi → Koh Lanta → Bangkok

This sacrifices some island variety in exchange for more time in the north.

Again, there is no “correct” route.

There is only the route that matches the trip you're actually trying to have.

WHICH ROUTE IS RIGHT FOR YOU?

If you want the **classic first Thailand experience**, choose:

Bangkok → Chiang Mai → islands.

If you want **culture and food**, prioritise Bangkok and Chiang Mai.

If you want **beaches and relaxation**, prioritise the Andaman or Gulf side and avoid unnecessary inland detours.

If you want **diving**, build around Koh Tao.

If you want **nightlife**, look at Bangkok, Phuket or Koh Phangan depending on the type of nightlife you want.

If you want **a slower island trip**, consider Koh Lanta.

If you want **dramatic scenery and boat trips**, look at Krabi and the Andaman coast.

If you want **the easiest possible first trip**, choose fewer destinations and use domestic flights where they genuinely save time.

The final test is simple:

Look at every transfer in your itinerary.

If removing one destination makes the trip feel better, remove it.

Thailand isn't going anywhere.

You can always come back.

10 — YOUR FINAL THAILAND CHECKLIST

A great Thailand trip isn't created by adding more destinations.

It is created by making sure the route you've chosen actually works.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Decide what you want the holiday to feel like.

City? Culture? Food? Adventure? Beaches? Diving? Nightlife? Relaxation? Choose your priorities before choosing your destinations. Check the weather for the specific regions you're visiting.

If you're choosing between the Andaman and Gulf islands, look at the seasonal conditions for both rather than assuming all of southern Thailand has identical weather.

Build the route before booking hotels. Check the major flights, trains and ferries first. Then book accommodation around those connections.

BEFORE YOU FLY

Check your passport's current entry requirements.

If you're travelling on a British or Irish passport, check the latest Thai Embassy information immediately before departure because visa-exemption rules have recently changed.

Complete the **Thailand Digital Arrival Card** within the required timeframe before arrival. The TDAC is free and is not a visa.

Have your first accommodation confirmed. Keep the address accessible offline. Take out travel insurance that matches your activities.

If you're planning to ride a scooter, dive, trek or take part in adventure activities, check that you're properly covered.

YOUR ROUTE

Look at every travel day.

Ask how much time each transfer actually consumes.

Avoid changing islands every two nights.

Give important destinations enough time to justify the journey.

Leave a buffer before international flights.

Don't schedule a long ferry journey immediately before a critical flight.

YOUR EXPERIENCES

Choose the **three experiences you absolutely don't want to miss**.

These should determine the itinerary.

For one traveller, that might be:

Bangkok street food → Chiang Mai temples → island diving.

For another:

Bangkok nightlife → Full Moon Party → beach recovery.

For another:

Northern Thailand → cooking class → Koh Lanta.

There is no correct list.

The point is that the itinerary should be built around **you**, not around what appears in every Thailand TikTok.

YOUR TRANSPORT

Check the actual departure points. Confirm ferry terminals. Allow realistic airport transfer times. Book important flights and trains ahead when necessary. Don't rely on a tight connection between independent bookings.

If you're using a scooter, make sure your licence and insurance arrangements are appropriate.

YOUR MONEY

Set your daily budget before you leave. Thailand can be very cheap, but costs rise quickly once you add flights, islands, private transfers, diving, nightlife and better accommodation. Save money where it doesn't affect the experience.

Don't save £20 on the activity you've travelled 6,000 miles to do.

YOUR PACKING

Travel light. You will probably move through airports, trains, taxis, ferries and hotels.

Bring lightweight clothes, comfortable shoes, swimwear, sun protection and something appropriate for temples.

Pack a light layer if you're going north or into the mountains.

THE FINAL TEST

Before you leave, ask yourself:

Am I excited about every major destination?

Have I allowed enough time in each place?

Are the transfers realistic?

Have I chosen the right island region for my dates?

Have I protected the experiences that matter most?

Does this actually feel like a holiday?

If the answer to any of these is no, change the itinerary. Remove something. Add another night. Fly instead of taking an unnecessarily long journey. Choose one island instead of three. Leave some space. Thailand is incredibly easy to return to. You do not need to finish the country in one trip.

OUTBOUND RULE: The best Thailand itinerary is the one that leaves you thinking **"I wish we'd stayed another week"**, not **"thank God we're going home."**

OUTBOUND

Fewer places. Better trips.